

Prince Caspian

The Return to Narnia — C.S. Lewis, 1951

Where *The Lion, the Witch and the Wardrobe* is about first belief, this one is about **holding faith when the world has moved on and the signs have gone quiet**. That's the whole book — keep it in mind and every scene lines up behind it.

The story in a paragraph

The four Pevensie children are yanked off an English train platform back into Narnia — but centuries have passed. The Narnia they once ruled is now ruined and overgrown, conquered by the **Telmarines**, a human people who drove the Talking Beasts and old magic into hiding and stopped believing any of it was real. Young **Prince Caspian**, the rightful heir, flees his usurping uncle **Miraz**, finds the "Old Narnians" still alive underground, and blows **Susan's magic horn** to call for help — which is what pulled the children back. The rest is a hard journey to reach Caspian (where they get lost by ignoring Aslan), and a war to put the true king on the throne — won when **Aslan** returns and wakes the land itself.

Who's who (the ones that carry a theme)

- **Caspian** — the young prince raised on forbidden stories of old Narnia, who turns out to actually believe them.
- **Lucy** — youngest Pevensie; the first and, for a while, the *only* one to see Aslan. The book's spiritual center.
- **Miraz** — the usurping uncle; a man who decided the old world doesn't exist because believing it is inconvenient.
- **Trumpkin** — a loyal but skeptical dwarf who doesn't believe in Aslan or the children — until he sees.
- **Reepicheep** — the valiant talking mouse. Tiny, fearless, all honor — the picture of courage.
- **Aslan** — the great Lion, mostly absent from the page until late. His absence *is* the point.

Themes at a glance

- **Faith when God seems absent** — Aslan hasn't been seen for generations; the test is believing before you see.
- **Following even when you're alone** — Aslan tells Lucy she should have obeyed him even if no one else would come.

- **Faith is meant to grow** — "Every year you grow, you will find me bigger."
- **Restoration, not just victory** — Aslan doesn't only win the battle; he brings the dead land back to life.
- **Courage isn't about size** — Reepicheep the mouse is braver than soldiers ten times his size.
- **Truth outlasts those who bury it** — Miraz denied old Narnia existed; it was real the whole time.

The themes in depth

Faith when God seems absent

Narnia has "modernized." The trees sleep, the Talking Beasts hide, and Aslan hasn't been seen in generations — belief in him is now a children's fairy tale the grown-ups have outgrown. Lewis is drawing a world that has quietly explained God away, not by arguing against him but by acting as if he was never there. The question the book keeps asking isn't *is Aslan real* — it's *will you act on him when there's no proof in front of you*.

Following even when you're alone

At the book's quiet center, Lucy alone sees Aslan and says they must follow him up a path that looks wrong. The others outvote her and take the easier road — and it costs them; they get lost and have to backtrack. Later Aslan tells Lucy the hardest thing in the book: she should have followed him *even alone*, even if not a single person came with her. Obedience isn't supposed to wait for the group to agree.

Faith is meant to grow

When Lucy meets Aslan again she says he looks bigger. He explains it isn't that *he* has grown — it's that *she* has: "Every year you grow, you will find me bigger." Faith isn't meant to stay the child-sized thing you first believed; a God you understood completely at seven would be too small to follow at forty.

Restoration, not just victory

When Aslan finally acts, he doesn't only win the battle. He *wakes the trees and the river-god*, frees a joyless schoolroom, and undoes the deadening the Telmarines brought. The victory isn't just a change of king — it's the whole world coming back to life. Aslan restores; he doesn't merely defeat.

Courage isn't about size

Reepicheep the mouse carries the book's picture of valor. He's absurdly small and absurdly brave, measuring greatness by honor and heart rather than strength. Set against him is Miraz — powerful, armed, and a coward at the core. Lewis keeps flipping who the "big" and "small" people really are.

Truth outlasts those who bury it

Miraz and the Telmarines ruled by insisting old Narnia never existed — rewriting the story to keep their power. But the trees, the Beasts, and Aslan were real the entire time, just driven underground. Denying the truth didn't make it untrue; it only delayed the day it woke back up.

Passages to slow down on

- Lucy's night walk to find Aslan again, and the reunion where he grows as she looks — the "you'll find me bigger" exchange.
- Aslan gently asking Lucy why she didn't come to him alone. It doesn't let her off the hook.
- Trumpkin the skeptic meeting Aslan — and being tossed in the air like a puppy. Doubt met with play, not a lecture.
- The waking of the trees and the river near the end — the land itself coming alive.

"Aslan," said Lucy, "you're bigger." "That is because you are older, little one," answered he. "Not because you are?" "I am not. But every year you grow, you will find me bigger."

— Prince Caspian

3 questions to ask

- 1 Why did almost everyone in Narnia stop believing in Aslan — and what finally made them see him again?
- 2 Aslan told Lucy she should have followed him even if she had to go alone. When is it hard to do the right thing by yourself?
- 3 Aslan is a picture of Jesus. What does this story show about trusting God even when you can't see him?

Reading guide · a memory aid for the themes + 3 questions to ask · companion to the Prince Caspian note